

Career Planning and Management

Module 2: Behavioural Traits

Exam Ready Notes — CS / BCA Students

Contents

1	Identification of Behavioural Traits	3
1.1	What are Behavioural Traits?	3
1.2	Why Identify Behavioural Traits?	3
1.3	Methods of Identifying Behavioural Traits	3
1.4	DISC Model of Behavioural Traits	3
1.5	Categories of Behavioural Traits	3
2	Understanding Key Traits	4
2.1	Adaptability	4
2.1.1	Why It Matters	4
2.1.2	Dimensions of Adaptability	4
2.1.3	How to Develop Adaptability	4
2.2	Leadership	4
2.2.1	Key Leadership Styles	4
2.2.2	Core Leadership Traits	4
2.2.3	Emotional Intelligence (Goleman's Model)	5
2.3	Communication	5
2.3.1	Types of Communication	5
2.3.2	Communication Process Model	5
2.3.3	Barriers to Effective Communication	5
2.3.4	Effective Communication Skills	6
3	Organisational Culture	6
3.1	Definition	6
3.2	Components of Organisational Culture	6
3.3	Schein's Three Levels of Culture	6
3.4	Types of Organisational Culture (Charles Handy)	6
3.5	Competing Values Framework (Quinn & Rohrbaugh)	7
3.6	Importance of Organisational Culture	7
4	Fostering Teamwork and Enhancing Workplace Harmony	7
4.1	Definition of Teamwork	7
4.2	Tuckman's Stages of Team Development	7
4.3	Belbin's Team Roles	7
4.4	Workplace Harmony	8
4.4.1	Strategies to Foster Teamwork and Harmony	8
4.4.2	Conflict Management Styles (Thomas-Kilmann Model)	8

5	Corporate Competencies	8
5.1	Definition	8
5.2	Types of Competencies	8
5.3	Competency Framework	9
5.4	Prahalad and Hamel's Core Competency Theory	9
6	Problem-Solving with Competencies	9
6.1	Problem-Solving as a Core Competency	9
6.2	Problem-Solving Frameworks	9
6.2.1	1. The PDCA Cycle (Plan-Do-Check-Act)	9
6.2.2	2. Root Cause Analysis (5 Whys)	9
6.2.3	3. The IDEAL Model	10
6.2.4	4. Design Thinking	10
6.3	Competencies that Drive Career Success	10
6.4	Competencies and Organisational Performance	10
7	Quick Revision Summary	10

Identification of Behavioural Traits

What are Behavioural Traits?

Behavioural traits are **consistent patterns of behaviour, thought, and emotion** that define how a person acts in various situations — particularly in a professional context.

They are different from personality (which is innate/stable) in that traits can be *observed, measured, and developed* over time.

Why Identify Behavioural Traits?

- Helps individuals understand their **strengths and areas of improvement**
- Enables organisations to **match people to roles** effectively
- Guides **career development** and training
- Predicts **job performance and cultural fit**

Methods of Identifying Behavioural Traits

1. **Psychometric Tests** — Standardised tools (e.g., MBTI, DISC, Big Five OCEAN)
2. **Behavioural Interviews** — Situational/competency-based questions (“Tell me about a time when...”)
3. **360-Degree Feedback** — Feedback from peers, subordinates, and supervisors
4. **Observation and Self-Reflection** — Journaling, mentoring, coaching
5. **Assessment Centres** — Role plays, group exercises, in-tray exercises

DISC Model of Behavioural Traits

One of the most widely used behavioural frameworks in organisations:

Type	Key Trait	Work Style
D — Dominance	Direct, results-oriented	Takes charge, decisive
I — Influence	Enthusiastic, persuasive	Collaborative, social
S — Steadiness	Patient, dependable	Team player, avoids conflict
C — Conscientiousness	Analytical, accurate	Detail-oriented, follows rules

Exam Tip: DISC is a **behavioural** model; MBTI and Big Five are **personality** models. Know the difference.

Categories of Behavioural Traits

- **Positive Traits:** Adaptability, leadership, communication, empathy, integrity, initiative
- **Traits to Develop:** Impulsiveness, avoidance of conflict, overconfidence, inflexibility
- **Observable vs Hidden Traits:** Observable = communication style, punctuality; Hidden = values, motivation

Understanding Key Traits

Adaptability

Definition: The ability to adjust thinking, behaviour, and approach in response to changing circumstances, new information, or unexpected challenges.

2.1.1 Why It Matters

- Technology and job markets change rapidly — adaptable employees thrive
- Linked to **resilience** and **learning agility**
- Reduces resistance to change in organisations

2.1.2 Dimensions of Adaptability

1. **Cognitive Adaptability** — Changing the way you think; embracing new ideas
2. **Emotional Adaptability** — Managing emotions during uncertainty or change
3. **Interpersonal Adaptability** — Adjusting communication style to different people
4. **Situational Adaptability** — Responding effectively to different environments/contexts

2.1.3 How to Develop Adaptability

- Embrace a **growth mindset** (Carol Dweck) — believe abilities can be developed
- Seek **new experiences** and step out of the comfort zone
- Practice **reflective learning** after challenges
- Build **stress-management** skills

Exam Tip: Adaptability = Growth Mindset + Resilience + Openness to Change. Often tested with scenario-based questions.

Leadership

Definition: The ability to *guide, motivate, and influence* individuals or groups toward achieving a common goal.

2.2.1 Key Leadership Styles

Style	Approach	Best For
Autocratic	Leader decides alone	Crisis situations, new teams
Democratic	Involves team in decisions	Creative, experienced teams
Laissez-Faire	Minimal guidance, team self-directs	Highly skilled, autonomous teams
Transformational	Inspires vision and change	Innovation, long-term growth
Transactional	Rewards and punishments	Routine tasks, short-term goals
Servant Leadership	Leader serves the team's needs	People-focused organisations

2.2.2 Core Leadership Traits

- **Vision** — Clarity of direction and purpose
- **Integrity** — Consistency between words and actions

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- **Emotional Intelligence (EI/EQ)** — Self-awareness, empathy, self-regulation
 - **Decision-Making** — Ability to decide under uncertainty
 - **Accountability** — Owning results, good or bad

2.2.3 Emotional Intelligence (Goleman's Model)

Daniel Goleman identified **5 components** of EQ crucial for leadership:

1. Self-Awareness
2. Self-Regulation
3. Motivation (intrinsic)
4. Empathy
5. Social Skills

Exam Tip: EQ is considered more important than IQ in leadership. Goleman's 5 components are frequently asked.

Communication

Definition: The process of exchanging information, ideas, and emotions between individuals or groups, effectively and clearly.

2.3.1 Types of Communication

- **Verbal** — Spoken words (face-to-face, calls, presentations)
- **Non-Verbal** — Body language, gestures, facial expressions, eye contact
- **Written** — Emails, reports, documentation
- **Visual** — Charts, graphs, infographics

2.3.2 Communication Process Model

Sender → Encoding → Message → Channel → Decoding → Receiver → Feedback

Noise (barriers) can distort the message at any stage.

2.3.3 Barriers to Effective Communication

- **Physical:** Distance, noise, technology issues
- **Semantic:** Jargon, language differences, ambiguity
- **Psychological:** Preconceptions, stress, lack of interest
- **Cultural:** Differences in customs, values, communication norms
- **Organisational:** Hierarchy, information overload, lack of feedback channels

2.3.4 Effective Communication Skills

- **Active Listening** — Fully concentrating, not just hearing
- **Clarity and Conciseness** — Avoiding ambiguity
- **Empathy** — Understanding the receiver's perspective
- **Assertiveness** — Expressing needs without aggression or passivity
- **Feedback** — Closing the communication loop

Exam Tip: “7 Cs of Communication” — Clear, Concise, Concrete, Correct, Coherent, Complete, Courteous.

Organisational Culture

Definition

Organisational culture is the **shared set of values, beliefs, norms, and practices** that characterise an organisation and guide its members' behaviour.

It is often described as “*the way we do things around here.*”

Components of Organisational Culture

- **Values** — Core principles (e.g., integrity, innovation, customer focus)
- **Norms** — Unwritten rules of behaviour
- **Symbols** — Logo, dress code, office layout
- **Rituals and Ceremonies** — Team meetings, annual events, onboarding
- **Heroes** — Role models celebrated within the organisation
- **Stories and Myths** — Narratives that reinforce cultural values

Schein's Three Levels of Culture

Edgar Schein (same as Career Anchors) proposed three layers:

1. **Artefacts** — Visible structures: office design, dress code, ceremonies (surface level)
2. **Espoused Values** — Stated values and strategies (middle level)
3. **Basic Assumptions** — Deep-rooted, unconscious beliefs (deepest level)

Exam Tip: Schein appears in both Module 1 (Career Anchors) and Module 2 (Organisational Culture). A favourite exam question.

Types of Organisational Culture (Charles Handy)

Culture Type	Symbol	Characteristics
Power Culture	Spider's web	Centralised power, few rules, fast decisions
Role Culture	Greek temple	Bureaucratic, defined roles, rules-based
Task Culture	Net/matrix	Team-focused, project-oriented, flexible
Person Culture	Cluster	Individual-centric, experts, minimal structure

Competing Values Framework (Quinn & Rohrbaugh)

Culture	Focus
Clan	Collaboration, family-like, loyalty
Adhocracy	Innovation, risk-taking, entrepreneurship
Market	Competition, results, goal achievement
Hierarchy	Control, efficiency, structured processes

Importance of Organisational Culture

- Influences employee motivation and engagement
- Shapes customer experience and brand image
- Drives retention and recruitment
- Determines how change is managed
- Aligns individual behaviour with organisational goals

Fostering Teamwork and Enhancing Workplace Harmony

Definition of Teamwork

Teamwork is the **collaborative effort of a group** to achieve a common goal in a way that is more effective than individual effort alone.

Tuckman's Stages of Team Development

1. **Forming** — Team members meet, roles unclear, polite behaviour
2. **Storming** — Conflicts arise, power struggles, differing opinions
3. **Norming** — Norms established, cooperation improves, roles clarified
4. **Performing** — High performance, self-directed, goal-focused
5. **Adjourning** — Team disbands after goal completion (added later)

Exam Tip: Tuckman's model is **very frequently asked**. Remember the 5 stages in order.

Belbin's Team Roles

Meredith Belbin identified **9 team roles** grouped into three categories:

Category	Role	Contribution
Action-Oriented	Shaper	Challenges team, drives progress
	Implementer	Turns ideas into actions
	Completer-Finisher	Ensures quality, meets deadlines
People-Oriented	Coordinator	Clarifies goals, delegates well
	Team Worker	Cooperative, diplomatic
	Resource Investigator	Explores opportunities, networker
Thought-Oriented	Plant	Creative, problem-solver
	Monitor-Evaluator	Analytical, impartial judge
	Specialist	Deep expertise in specific area

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Workplace Harmony

Definition: A state of peaceful coexistence and positive relationships in the workplace, enabling productivity and well-being.

4.4.1 Strategies to Foster Teamwork and Harmony

- **Clear Goals** — Everyone knows what they are working toward
- **Open Communication** — Transparent and honest information sharing
- **Conflict Resolution** — Address disagreements promptly and fairly
- **Inclusive Leadership** — Valuing diverse perspectives
- **Recognition and Appreciation** — Acknowledging contributions
- **Psychological Safety** — Employees feel safe to speak up without fear
- **Work-Life Balance** — Respecting personal boundaries

4.4.2 Conflict Management Styles (Thomas-Kilmann Model)

Style	Description
Competing	Win-lose; assertive, uncooperative
Collaborating	Win-win; assertive, cooperative
Compromising	Middle ground; both partially satisfied
Avoiding	Ignores conflict; neither assertive nor cooperative
Accommodating	Yields to others; unassertive, cooperative

Exam Tip: **Collaborating** = best long-term strategy. **Competing** = useful only in emergencies.

Corporate Competencies

Definition

Corporate competencies (also called **organisational competencies** or **core competencies**) are the *skills, knowledge, and behaviours* that the organisation values and expects from all employees regardless of role.

Types of Competencies

1. **Core/Generic Competencies** — Expected of everyone in the organisation
Examples: integrity, communication, teamwork
2. **Functional/Technical Competencies** — Role-specific skills
Examples: programming (CS), data analysis, system design
3. **Leadership Competencies** — Required for managerial roles
Examples: strategic thinking, decision-making, people development
4. **Behavioural Competencies** — Soft skills that influence performance
Examples: adaptability, emotional intelligence, accountability

Competency Framework

A **competency framework** is a structured model that defines the competencies required for various roles within an organisation.

Components of a Competency Framework:

- Competency name and definition
- Behavioural indicators (what it looks like in practice)
- Proficiency levels (e.g., beginner, proficient, expert)

Prahalad and Hamel's Core Competency Theory

C.K. Prahalad and Gary Hamel (1990) defined **core competency** as the organisation's collective knowledge and capability that:

- Provides access to a variety of markets
- Makes a significant contribution to perceived customer benefits
- Is **difficult for competitors to imitate**

Example: Apple's core competency = seamless integration of hardware, software, and services.

Exam Tip: Prahalad and Hamel = organisational core competency. Often asked as a definition or example question.

Problem-Solving with Competencies

Problem-Solving as a Core Competency

Problem-solving is one of the most valued competencies in both career success and organisational performance. It involves:

- Identifying the root cause of a problem
- Generating and evaluating possible solutions
- Implementing the best solution
- Reviewing outcomes

Problem-Solving Frameworks

6.2.1 1. The PDCA Cycle (Plan-Do-Check-Act)

Plan → Do → Check → Act → (repeat)

Also called the **Deming Cycle**. Used for continuous improvement.

6.2.2 2. Root Cause Analysis (5 Whys)

Ask "Why?" five times to get to the root cause of a problem.

Example:

1. Why did the system crash? — Server overloaded.
2. Why was the server overloaded? — Too many concurrent requests.
3. Why too many requests? — No load balancing.

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4. Why no load balancing? — Not included in design.
 5. Why not in design? — No performance requirement was specified.

Root Cause: Requirements were incomplete.

6.2.3 3. The IDEAL Model

I — Identify	Recognise the problem
D — Define	Clearly define the problem
E — Explore	Generate possible solutions
A — Act	Implement the chosen solution
L — Look Back	Evaluate effectiveness

6.2.4 4. Design Thinking

A human-centred approach to problem-solving:

1. **Empathise** — Understand the user's needs
2. **Define** — Frame the problem clearly
3. **Ideate** — Brainstorm solutions
4. **Prototype** — Build a quick model/solution
5. **Test** — Gather feedback and refine

Competencies that Drive Career Success

Competency	Career Relevance
Communication	Builds relationships, conveys ideas clearly
Problem-Solving	Valued across all roles and industries
Adaptability	Essential in fast-changing tech environments
Teamwork	Required in almost all professional roles
Leadership	Opens doors to managerial and senior roles
Emotional Intelligence	Reduces conflict, improves collaboration
Time Management	Increases productivity and reliability
Critical Thinking	Supports better decisions and innovations

Competencies and Organisational Performance

- Organisations with strong competency frameworks show higher **employee productivity**
- Competency-based hiring leads to better **job-person fit**
- Competency gaps identified in appraisals guide **training and development**
- Core competencies create **competitive advantage** (Prahalad & Hamel)
- Behavioural competencies improve **team cohesion and culture**

Quick Revision Summary

- **Behavioural Traits:** Identified via DISC, psychometric tests, 360-degree feedback
- **Key Traits:**
 - Adaptability = Growth Mindset + Resilience (4 dimensions)

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- Leadership = Vision + EQ + Decision-Making (Goleman: 5 EQ components)
 - Communication = 7 Cs; Barriers: Physical, Semantic, Psychological, Cultural
 - **Organisational Culture:**
 - Schein's 3 levels: Artefacts → Espoused Values → Basic Assumptions
 - Handy's 4 types: Power, Role, Task, Person
 - Quinn's 4 types: Clan, Adhocracy, Market, Hierarchy
 - **Teamwork:**
 - Tuckman's 5 stages: Forming, Storming, Norming, Performing, Adjourning
 - Belbin's 9 roles: Action, People, Thought oriented
 - Thomas-Kilmann: Collaborating = best; Competing = crisis only
 - **Corporate Competencies:** Core, Functional, Leadership, Behavioural
 - **Problem-Solving:** PDCA, 5 Whys, IDEAL, Design Thinking

“Behaviour is the mirror in which everyone shows their image.” — Goethe